

Position in society

Gladiators generally held a low position in Roman society. Many were prisoners captured in war or criminals condemned to fight. But there were also those who willingly became gladiators. Some were desperate or in debt, knowing that they would be taken care of. Others loved to fight and hoped to win the cheers of the crowd. When a free person became a gladiator, they gave up their legal rights.

Despite their low position in society, gladiators were not short of admirers. Those who fought well and lived to see another day attracted fans, many of whom were women. We know this from the



IN THIS SCENE FROM A MOSAIC MADE IN THE 4TH CENTURY CE, A VICTORIOUS GLADIATOR STANDS OVER THE BODY OF HIS VICTIM.

WEIRD WORLD

IF A ROMAN MAN HAD A DREAM INVOLVING A TYPE OF GLADIATOR KNOWN AS A *THRAEX*, IT WAS TAKEN AS A SIGN THAT HE WAS GOING TO MARRY A RICH WOMAN!

graffiti people left on the walls of arenas in which their heroes fought.

At the arena in Pompeii, a small Roman town in southern Italy, a gladiator named Celadus was described as a "girls' hero" and a "heartthrob," while another, called Crescens, was hailed as "the boss."